

The Story of an Hour

Kate Chopin · 1894

First published: Vogue, Dec 1894

TEACHER EDITION · CURRICULUM UNIT

Common Core edition (standards shown for this framework only)

One 90-minute lesson (the whole story), with an optional take-home essay

Syllabus · 90-minute lesson plans · lecture scripts · vocabulary · quizzes with keys · writing prompts at eleven rigor levels · SAT-style items · whole-book test · essays

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Contents and unit overview

1. Unit overview and the 90-minute lesson
2. Syllabus (weekly pacing)
3. Lesson 1: introduction (author, context, reception, overview)
4. Lesson plans and lecture scripts (chapters 1–1), each with vocabulary, discussion questions, annotation focus, quiz and key, writing prompts and SAT-style items
5. Unit test (eleven rigor versions) with answer keys and scoring guides
6. Final paper
7. Essay assignments at eleven rigor levels

Edition: Reading text: https://en.wikisource.org/wiki/The_Story_of_an_Hour (revision 13961357), cleaned for Liber et Libri.

Grades: Grades 9–12 (scales to graduate via rigor levels). Short story: read whole in one 90-minute lesson (assign longer stories as pre-reading). The scaffolded-support track works from the full text with scaffolds. **Weeks:** 1. **Class days:** 2 × 90 minutes (1 chapter lessons plus seminar, test and essay days).

Essential questions

- What does The Story of an Hour suggest about freedom and marriage?
- What does The Story of an Hour suggest about identity?
- What does The Story of an Hour suggest about irony of joy?

Objectives

- Students will cite at least 2 quotations, with locations, to support each written claim about what the text says explicitly and implicitly (scored on the writing-prompt rubric).
- Students will trace one theme across at least 3 sections of the story in the final paper, earning at least 70 of 100 rubric points.
- Students will explain how characters, setting and point of view interact in at least 3 exit tickets, each meeting the claim-evidence-reasoning criteria.
- Students will determine the in-context meaning of taught vocabulary, scoring at least 80% on the vocabulary items of the story quizzes.
- Students will write an argument with a clear claim, reasons and relevant evidence, scoring at least 80% on the unit test's short-answer scoring guides.

Standards: Common Core

RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2, RL.9-10.3, RL.9-10.4, RL.9-10.5, RL.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2, RL.11-12.4, RL.11-12.5, W.9-10.1, W.11-12.1, L.9-10.4, L.11-12.4

Common Core State Standards (ELA-Literacy), thecorestandards.org

Assessments: Daily story quizzes (auto-graded); Weekly writing prompt (rubric); Socratic seminars (scheduled days); Whole-story test (scheduled day); Final essay (scheduled day); College Sophomore and above write one essay of the five
Differentiation: Every prompt and quiz has eleven rigor levels (Scaffolded support through Graduate / PhD); the app applies student override, then class standard, then the automatic level. Each prompt is tagged for Common Core, Indiana 2023, Dual Credit (Indiana College Core), AP and Cambridge where they apply.
Materials: Liber et Libri reader; Annotation journal; Story lecture slides or script

The 90-minute lesson

#	Segment	Mode	Minutes	Clock
1	Bell-ringer	You do	8	0–8
2	Vocabulary with etymology notes	I do	10	8–18
3	Background and context	I do	10	18–28
4	I do: modeled close reading	I do	12	28–40
5	We do: guided annotation	We do	15	40–55
6	You do: independent annotation	You do	15	55–70
7	Discussion	We do	10	70–80
8	Exit ticket / chapter quiz	You do	7	80–87
9	Closure	I do	3	87–90
	Total		**90**	

Syllabus

Week	Chapters	Lessons	Focus and activities	Assessment
1	*Introduction: author, context and reception* The Story of an Hour	2 × 90 min (180 min)	*freedom and marriage* • Daily 90-minute lesson: bell-ringer, vocabulary and word histories, background, I do / We do / You do, discussion, exit ticket, closure • Story quizzes in the app • Introduction: author, context and reception • Writing prompt at assigned rigor (one graded per week)	Quiz average plus one graded writing prompt

Lesson plans and lecture scripts

Each chapter is one 90-minute class. Scripts are a starting point; adapt them to your students. Teacher summaries contain spoilers.

Lesson 1: Introduction to The Story of an Hour

Objective: Students will explain, in a 3-sentence exit ticket, how one fact about Kate Chopin's life or times connects to freedom and marriage in “The Story of an Hour”, and will set up a reading journal with a prediction and a question for each of 3 themes (freedom and marriage, identity, irony of joy).

Standards: Common Core RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2

Author biography

Kate Chopin was born Katherine O'Flaherty in St. Louis on 8 February 1850. She married the Louisiana cotton trader Oscar Chopin and lived in New Orleans and Cloutierville among Creole and Cajun communities. Widowed in 1882 with six children, she returned to St. Louis and began writing; her stories appeared in Vogue and other magazines and were collected in Bayou Folk (1894). Her story The Awakening (1899), about a married woman's desire for independence, was condemned by reviewers. She died on 22 August 1904; her work was rediscovered in the 1960s.

Historical and cultural context

In the 1890s, married American women had limited legal identities; the "new woman" debate about women's independence was intense.

Publication and reception, then and now

Written on 19 April 1894 and first published as "The Dream of an Hour" in Vogue on 6 December 1894.

Then: Little noticed.

Now: A brief, widely taught feminist classic with a famous ironic ending.

Overview (spoiler-free)

Louise Mallard, who has a heart condition, learns that her husband has been killed in a railroad accident.

Main themes

- freedom and marriage.
- irony.
- self-assertion.

Why it matters

It asks how social roles limit people, even in loving relationships.

Spoilers · teacher only

Alone, she realizes she is free; then her husband walks in alive, and she dies, the doctors say, "of the joy that kills."

Lesson plan (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
Before we open The Story of an Hour: What does freedom mean to you?
Prompt: Before we open The Story of an Hour: What does freedom mean to you?

8–18 min · Key terms · I do (10 min)
Key literary terms for the unit.
situational irony; dramatic irony; imagery.

18–28 min · Mini-lecture: author, context, reception · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture on the author, the historical context and the reception (read or adapt the script).
About the author. Kate Chopin was born Katherine O'Flaherty in St. Louis on 8 February 1850. She married the Louisiana cotton trader Oscar Chopin and lived in New Orleans and Cloutierville among Creole and Cajun communities. Widowed in 1882 with six children, she returned to St. Louis and began writing; her stories appeared in Vogue and other magazines and were collected in Bayou Folk (1894). Her story The Awakening (1899), about a married woman's desire for independence, was condemned by reviewers. She died on 22 August 1904; her work was rediscovered in the 1960s. The world of the book. In the 1890s, married American women had limited legal identities; the "new woman" debate about women's independence was intense. Publication and reception. Written on 19 April 1894 and first published as "The Dream of an Hour" in Vogue on 6 December 1894. Then: Little noticed. Now: A brief, widely taught feminist classic with a famous ironic ending.

28–40 min · I do: the book in one passage · I do (12 min)
Model a close reading of one passage using the written think-aloud below.
First, meaning. I read "Knowing that Mrs. Mallard was afflicted with a heart trouble, great care was taken to break to her as gently as possible the news of her..." slowly and put it in my own words: Because Mrs. Mallard has a heart condition, people take great care to tell her gently that her husband has died. Next, craft. I notice the passive voice, "care was taken," which hides who is doing it and makes her someone things are done to. The strongest word is "gently": it shows they think of her as fragile, a view the story will question. Then, effect. What does this careful, gentle opening sentence suggest about how people treat Mrs. Mallard? My answer: The people around her treat her as weak and protected, which is part of the life she will briefly feel free from.

> *Knowing that Mrs. Mallard was afflicted with a heart trouble, great care was taken to break to her as gently as possible the news of her husband's death. (The Story of an Hour, paragraph 1)*

Think-aloud: First, meaning. I read "Knowing that Mrs. Mallard was afflicted with a heart trouble, great care was taken to break to her as gently as possible the news of her…" slowly and put it in my own words: Because Mrs. Mallard has a heart condition, people take great care to tell her gently that her husband has died. Next, craft. I notice the passive voice, "care was taken," which hides who is doing it and makes her someone things are done to. The strongest word is "gently": it shows they think of her as fragile, a view the story will question. Then, effect. What does this careful, gentle opening sentence suggest about how people treat Mrs. Mallard? My answer: The people around her treat her as weak and protected, which is part of the life she will briefly feel free from.

40–55 min · We do: overview and themes · We do (15 min)
Read the spoiler-free overview together and name the themes to track.
What the book is about (no spoilers): Louise Mallard, who has a heart condition, learns that her husband has been killed in a railroad accident. Themes to track: freedom and marriage.: irony.: self-assertion.:

55–70 min · You do: reading journal · You do (15 min)
Set up a reading journal: one page per theme, with a prediction and a question (example given).
Set up a reading journal: one page per theme with a prediction and a question. Page: freedom and marriage. Prediction: Louise Mallard's reaction to news of her husband's death will not be the grief everyone expects. Question: what does she feel, alone in her room, that she cannot say aloud?
Task: Set up a reading journal for The Story of an Hour: one page per theme, each with a prediction and a question.
Exemplar: Page: freedom and marriage. Prediction: Louise Mallard's reaction to news of her husband's death will not be the grief everyone expects. Question: what does she feel, alone in her room, that she cannot say aloud?

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Whole-class discussion: why the book is still taught.
Why does The Story of an Hour still matter? It asks how social roles limit people, even in loving relationships.
Anchor question: Why might The Story of an Hour still be taught today?
Facilitation: It asks how social roles limit people, even in loving relationships.

80–87 min · Exit ticket · You do (7 min)
Exit ticket on the author and context (answer given).
Chopin was widowed at 32 and began writing to support her six children; she published "The Story of an Hour" in Vogue in 1894, and her story The Awakening was attacked by critics in 1899. What does that suggest about how society saw women who wrote about women's freedom? Answer: Accept answers such as: such writing was seen as shocking in 1890s America; women were expected to find fulfillment in marriage; Chopin wrote honestly about women's inner lives despite criticism of The Awakening.
Exit ticket: Chopin was widowed at 32 and began writing to support her six children; she published "The Story of an Hour" in Vogue in 1894, and her story The Awakening was attacked by critics in 1899. What does that suggest about how society saw women who wrote about women's freedom?
Answer: Accept answers such as: such writing was seen as shocking in 1890s America; women were expected to find fulfillment in marriage; Chopin wrote honestly about women's inner lives despite criticism of The Awakening.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Preview the first reading.
Tomorrow we begin reading: The Story of an Hour.

Teacher notes · sources: Kate Chopin International Society (https://www.katechopin.org/); Britannica, "Kate Chopin" (https://www.britannica.com/biography/Kate-Chopin); Kate Chopin International Society (https://www.katechopin.org/)

Lesson 2: The Story of an Hour

Focus: a woman's brief taste of freedom

Objective: Students will analyze how irony develops in “The Story of an Hour” by writing a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph that cites at least 2 quotations from the section, and will score at least 80% on the section quiz.

Standards: Common Core RL.9-10.1, W.9-10.1, L.9-10.4

Content note (death, marriage as constraint, alcohol or drugs (mentioned)): Sensitive content: Death; marriage as constraint. Preview the story, tell students in advance, and allow a pass on reading aloud. Keep discussion on how the writer uses these elements, not on graphic detail. This section mentions drinking or a drug (“…Go away. I am not making myself ill." No; she was drinking in a very elixir of life through that o…”). Treat it as period custom or plot detail; name it plainly and don't glamorize it.
Student preview: Heads-up: this story includes death; marriage as constraint.
Suggested language: “Why does the writer include this, and what does it make us notice?”

Teacher only · spoilers

Told gently that her husband Brently has died in a railroad accident, Louise Mallard weeps, then alone in her room feels a growing, monstrous joy: 'Free, free, free!' She looks ahead to years that will belong to herself. Leaving the room, she sees Brently walk in the door, unharmed; he had not been on the train. She dies, and the doctors say of 'the joy that kills'.

Background: Published in Vogue in 1894, when married women's legal identity was still largely bound up in their husbands'.

Significance: Very widely anthologized; its last line is a famous case of dramatic irony.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
What does freedom mean to you? Can you feel free and loved at the same time? Write for five minutes. Starters: I think... because... / This connects to freedom and marriage because.... Content note before we start: Heads-up: this story includes death; marriage as constraint.
Prompt: What does freedom mean to you? Can you feel free and loved at the same time?
Sentence starters: I think… because… · This connects to freedom and marriage because…
Strong response: A strong response takes a position and anticipates this: she does not hate her husband but loves her freedom.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Five key words in context, with verified word histories.
Today's words: elusive — hard to grasp, catch or put into words; coursing — flowing quickly; composedly — in a self-collected or self-possessed manner; intelligent — having the capacity for thought and reason especially to a high degree; repression — the holding back of feelings or desires. "elusive": Origin: Latin elusus.
Words: elusive: hard to grasp, catch or put into words · coursing: flowing quickly · composedly: in a self-collected or self-possessed manner · intelligent: having the capacity for thought and reason especially to a high degree · repression: the holding back of feelings or desires

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture (read or adapt the script).
Published in Vogue in 1894, when married women's legal identity was still largely bound up in their husbands'. Very widely anthologized; its last line is a famous case of dramatic irony. Irony: The doctors misread her death. Imagery: Spring imagery outside her window signals new life. Characterization: Her "heart trouble" is literal and figurative. Watch for the open window: possibility.

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Model the close reading of the anchor quotation using the written think-aloud below.
First, meaning. I read "afflicted with a heart trouble" slowly and put it in my own words: Everyone handles the news gently because Mrs. Mallard has a weak heart. Next, craft. I notice the medical fact is presented first, before her name or the news, so it frames everything. The strongest word is "afflicted": it makes her sound fragile and passive, how others see her. Then, effect. Why does the story mention Mrs. Mallard's heart trouble in the very first line? My answer: The heart trouble shapes how others treat her and sets up the ending; Chopin plants it so that the final heart failure has a double meaning.

> *afflicted with a heart trouble* *(The Story of an Hour, paragraph 1)*

Think-aloud: First, meaning. I read "afflicted with a heart trouble" slowly and put it in my own words: Everyone handles the news gently because Mrs. Mallard has a weak heart. Next, craft. I notice the medical fact is presented first, before her name or the news, so it frames everything. The strongest word is "afflicted": it makes her sound fragile and passive, how others see her. Then, effect. Why does the story mention Mrs. Mallard's heart trouble in the very first line? My answer: The heart trouble shapes how others treat her and sets up the ending; Chopin plants it so that the final heart failure has a double meaning.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Guided analysis of a second quotation; expected answers given.
Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest? Expected: Repeating "free" shows her growing awareness. Ask: How does this line connect to freedom and marriage? Expected: She does not hate her husband but loves her freedom. (Realization.)

> *Free! Body and soul free* *(The Story of an Hour, paragraph 12)*

Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest?
Expected answer: Repeating "free" shows her growing awareness.
Ask: How does this line connect to freedom and marriage?
Expected answer: She does not hate her husband but loves her freedom. (Realization.)

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)
Independent annotation and a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph (exemplar given).
Annotate the story for irony, imagery (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this story suggest about a woman's brief taste of freedom? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how The Story of an Hour develops the idea of a woman's brief taste of freedom. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of irony and imagery shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) Exemplar: Chopin uses irony to show that Louise's death comes from lost freedom, not joy. When the text says “of the joy that kills” (The Story of an Hour, paragraph 19), it shows this directly. She whispers "Free! Body and soul free!", and when her husband returns the doctors say she died "of the joy that kills," a diagnosis the reader knows is wrong.
Task: Annotate the story for irony, imagery (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this story suggest about a woman's brief taste of freedom? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how The Story of an Hour develops the idea of a woman's brief taste of freedom. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of irony and imagery shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.)
Exemplar: Chopin uses irony to show that Louise's death comes from lost freedom, not joy. When the text says “of the joy that kills” (The Story of an Hour, paragraph 19), it shows this directly. She whispers "Free! Body and soul free!", and when her husband returns the doctors say she died "of the joy that kills," a diagnosis the reader knows is wrong.

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions, with facilitation notes.
Anchor question: What does freedom mean to you? Can you feel free and loved at the same time? Ask: was Louise's marriage bad?
Anchor question: What does freedom mean to you? Can you feel free and loved at the same time?
Facilitation: Ask: was Louise's marriage bad?

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)
Story quiz in the app and an exit ticket (answer given).
Story quiz in the app, then: In one sentence, what does this story suggest about a woman's brief taste of freedom? Support it with one short quotation. Model answer: Chopin uses irony to show that Louise's death comes from lost freedom, not joy. ("of the joy that kills", The Story of an Hour, paragraph 19). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the story; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.
Exit ticket: In one sentence, what does this story suggest about a woman's brief taste of freedom? Support it with one short quotation.
Answer: Model answer: Chopin uses irony to show that Louise's death comes from lost freedom, not joy. ("of the joy that kills", The Story of an Hour, paragraph 19). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the story; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
Today we saw how irony shapes a woman's brief taste of freedom. Key takeaway: she does not hate her husband but loves her freedom.

Total: 90 minutes.

Teacher analysis (spoilers)

Literary elements

- **Irony:** The doctors misread her death.
- **Imagery:** Spring imagery outside her window signals new life.
- **Characterization:** Her "heart trouble" is literal and figurative.

Themes and how they develop

- **freedom and marriage:** she does not hate her husband but loves her freedom.

Symbols and motifs

- **the open window:** possibility.

Key quotations (checked against the reading text)

- "Free! Body and soul free" (The Story of an Hour, paragraph 12) Realization.
- "afflicted with a heart trouble" (The Story of an Hour, paragraph 1) Literal and symbolic.
- "of the joy that kills" (The Story of an Hour, paragraph 19) The ironic end.

Model claim-evidence-reasoning

Claim: Chopin uses irony to show that Louise's death comes from lost freedom, not joy.
Evidence: "of the joy that kills" (The Story of an Hour, paragraph 19)

Reasoning: She whispers "Free! Body and soul free!", and when her husband returns the doctors say she died "of the joy that kills," a diagnosis the reader knows is wrong.

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
elusive (adjective)	hard to grasp, catch or put into words	*She did not know; it was too subtle and elusive to name.*	"elusive": Origin: Latin elusus. (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/elusive#Etymology)
coursing (verb)	flowing quickly	*Her pulses beat fast, and the coursing blood warmed and relaxed every inch of her body.*	
composedly (adverb)	in a self-collected or self-possessed manner	*It was Brently Mallard who entered, a little travel-stained, composedly carrying his grip-sack and umbrella.*	
intelligent (adjective)	having the capacity for thought and reason especially to a high degree	*It was not a glance of reflection, but rather indicated a suspension of intelligent thought.*	
repression (noun)	the holding back of feelings or desires	*She was young, with a fair, calm face, whose lines bespoke repression and even a certain strength.*	
tumultuously (adverb)	in a wild, stormy, excited way	*Now her bosom rose and fell tumultuously.*	"tumultuously": Origin of "tumultuous": Old French tumultuous; earlier Latin tumultuōsus ("restless"). (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/tumultuous#Etymology)
suspension (noun)	a pause in which something is held off or stopped	*It was not a glance of reflection, but rather indicated a suspension of intelligent thought.*	
persistence (noun)	continuing firmly in spite of difficulty	*There would be no powerful will bending hers in that blind persistence with which men and women believe they have a right to impose a private will upon a fellow-creature.*	
unwittingly (adverb)	without knowing or intending	*There was a feverish triumph in her eyes, and she carried herself*	"unwittingly": Origin: an English formation from unwitting + -ly. (Liber et Libri origin note, https://

		unwittingly like a goddess of Victory.	en.wiktionary.org/wiki/unwittingly#Etymology)
illumination (noun)	sudden understanding; a flash of insight	*A kind intention or a cruel intention made the act seem no less a crime as she looked upon it in that brief moment of illumination.*	

Discussion questions

1. What does freedom mean to you? Can you feel free and loved at the same time?
2. Where does irony appear in this story, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this story connect to the book's larger concern with freedom and marriage?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Scaffolded support: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. Why is Mrs. Mallard told the news carefully? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: She has heart trouble
2. Who first brings the news? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Her sister Josephine and Richards
3. What does she see from her window? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Signs of spring and new life
4. What word does she whisper? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Free
5. What do the doctors say killed her? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Heart disease, the joy that kills
6. Retell the three most important events of “The Story of an Hour” in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Told gently that her husband Brently has died in a railroad accident, Louise Mallard weeps, then alone in her room feels a growing, monstrous joy: 'Free, free, free!' She looks ahead to years that will belong to herself. Leaving the room, she sees Brently walk in the door, unharmed; he had not been on the train. She dies, and the doctors say of 'the joy that kills'.
7. Which characters appear or are mentioned in “The Story of an Hour”? Name two and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the story; check against the teacher summary.
8. Where and when does “The Story of an Hour” take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the story.

9. Reread: “She did not know; it was too subtle and elusive to name.” What does “elusive” mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: elusive: hard to grasp, catch or put into words.
10. Reread: “Her pulses beat fast, and the coursing blood warmed and relaxed every inch of her body.” What does “coursing” mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: coursing: flowing quickly.

Inferential / analytical

1. What does “The Story of an Hour” suggest about a woman's brief taste of freedom? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: Very widely anthologized; its last line is a famous case of dramatic irony.
2. Find one example of irony in this story. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.6] Look for: Look for gaps between what characters expect or say and what is true.
3. How does the imagery in this story shape what we understand about a woman's brief taste of freedom? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.4, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.4] Look for: Look for sensory details (sight, sound, cold, light) and what mood they create.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Chopin uses irony to show that Louise's death comes from lost freedom, not joy. Useful evidence: “Free! Body and soul free” (The Story of an Hour, paragraph 12): Realization. On imagery: Spring imagery outside her window signals new life. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
4. In the passage that begins “She was young, with a fair, calm face, whose lines bespoke repression and even a certain strength.”, why might Chopin have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.4, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.4] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
5. What causes the main turn in “The Story of an Hour”, and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Told gently that her husband Brently has died in a railroad accident, Louise Mallard weeps, then alone in her room feels a growing, monstrous joy: 'Free, free, free!' She looks ahead to years that will belong to herself. Leaving the room, she sees Brently walk in the door, unharmed; he had not been…
6. As the opening story, what does “The Story of an Hour” set up that the rest of The Story of an Hour will need? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous story.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Chopin uses irony to show that Louise's death comes from lost freedom, not joy. Useful evidence: “afflicted with a heart trouble” (The Story of an Hour, paragraph 1): Literal and symbolic. Theme link: she does not hate her husband but loves her freedom. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
7. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say and do here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Chopin uses irony to show that Louise's death comes from lost freedom, not joy. Useful evidence: “of the joy that kills” (The Story of an Hour, paragraph 19):

The ironic end. On characterization: Her "heart trouble" is literal and figurative. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

8. The bell-ringer asked: “What does freedom mean to you? Can you feel free and loved at the same time?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
9. Where does symbolism appear, and how does it connect this story to the larger concern with freedom and marriage? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.4, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.4] Look for: Look for objects, places or actions that stand for larger ideas.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Chopin uses irony to show that Louise's death comes from lost freedom, not joy. Useful evidence: “Free! Body and soul free” (The Story of an Hour, paragraph 12): Realization. Theme link: she does not hate her husband but loves her freedom. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
10. Background: Published in Vogue in 1894, when married women's legal identity was still largely bound up in their husbands'. How does knowing this change the way you read one moment in the story? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: A specific moment reread in light of the context.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Chopin uses irony to show that Louise's death comes from lost freedom, not joy. Useful evidence: “afflicted with a heart trouble” (The Story of an Hour, paragraph 1): Literal and symbolic. Theme link: she does not hate her husband but loves her freedom. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. A critic might argue: “Very widely anthologized; its last line is a famous case of dramatic irony.” How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the story. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Chopin uses irony to show that Louise's death comes from lost freedom, not joy. Useful evidence: “of the joy that kills” (The Story of an Hour, paragraph 19): The ironic end. Theme link: she does not hate her husband but loves her freedom. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
2. Which character in this story acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Chopin uses irony to show that Louise's death comes from lost freedom, not joy. Useful evidence: “Free! Body and soul free” (The Story of an Hour, paragraph 12): Realization. On characterization: Her "heart trouble" is literal and figurative. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
3. Rewrite one moment of “The Story of an Hour” from the point of view of a different character. What does the new angle reveal or hide about a woman's brief taste of freedom? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.6] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Chopin uses irony to show that Louise's death comes from lost freedom, not joy. Useful evidence: “afflicted with a heart trouble” (The Story of an Hour, paragraph 1): Literal and symbolic. Theme link: she does not hate her husband but loves her freedom.

Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

4. Write three questions of your own about “The Story of an Hour”: one recall, one “why/how”, and one “should/what if”. Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Chopin uses irony to show that Louise's death comes from lost freedom, not joy. Useful evidence: “of the joy that kills” (The Story of an Hour, paragraph 19): The ironic end. Theme link: she does not hate her husband but loves her freedom. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

5. Connect this story to identity: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Chopin need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Chopin uses irony to show that Louise's death comes from lost freedom, not joy. Useful evidence: “Free! Body and soul free” (The Story of an Hour, paragraph 12): Realization. Theme link: she does not hate her husband but loves her freedom. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

6. Is the irony in this story effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.6] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Chopin uses irony to show that Louise's death comes from lost freedom, not joy. Useful evidence: “afflicted with a heart trouble” (The Story of an Hour, paragraph 1): Literal and symbolic. On irony: The doctors misread her death. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

7. Compare how “The Story of an Hour” treats a woman's brief taste of freedom with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does The Story of an Hour see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Chopin uses irony to show that Louise's death comes from lost freedom, not joy. Useful evidence: “of the joy that kills” (The Story of an Hour, paragraph 19): The ironic end. Theme link: she does not hate her husband but loves her freedom. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

8. As the final story, does this ending resolve freedom and marriage? Argue whether the ending is earned. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Chopin uses irony to show that Louise's death comes from lost freedom, not joy. Useful evidence: “Free! Body and soul free” (The Story of an Hour, paragraph 12): Realization. Theme link: she does not hate her husband but loves her freedom. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

9. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this story (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about a woman's brief taste of freedom? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Chopin uses irony to show that Louise's death comes from lost freedom, not joy. Useful evidence: “afflicted with a heart trouble” (The Story of an Hour, paragraph 1): Literal and symbolic. Theme link: she does not hate her husband but loves her freedom.

Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

10. What question would you most like to ask Kate Chopin about this story, and what answer do you think the text itself gives? [DOK 4 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A student-generated question answered from evidence.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Chopin uses irony to show that Louise's death comes from lost freedom, not joy. Useful evidence: "of the joy that kills" (The Story of an Hour, paragraph 19): The ironic end. Theme link: she does not hate her husband but loves her freedom. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Annotation focus

- **Irony:** look for gaps between what characters expect or say and what is true (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Imagery**: sensory details (sight, sound, cold, light) and what mood they create
- Also notice **Symbolism**: objects, places or actions that stand for larger ideas

Chapter quiz: item bank (all eleven rigor versions)

1. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Who first brings the news?
   A. Brently himself
   B. The doctor
   C. A telegram boy
   D. Her sister Josephine and Richards

   Key: D (Her sister Josephine and Richards)
2. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "Now her bosom rose and fell _____."
   Word bank: elusive, coursing, composedly, tumultuously
   Key: tumultuously
3. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What does she see from her window?
   A. A train
   B. A funeral
   C. Signs of spring and new life
   D. Rain and fog

   Key: C (Signs of spring and new life)
4. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "It was not a glance of reflection, but rather indicated a _____ of intelligent thought." Word bank: suspension, composedly, elusive, coursing
   Key: suspension
5. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "There would be no powerful will bending hers in that blind _____ with which men and women believe they have a right to impose a private will upon a fellow-creature." Word bank: elusive, coursing, persistence, composedly
   Key: persistence
6. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What word does she whisper?
   A. Gone

B. Lost

C. Alone

D. Free

Key: D (Free)

7. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Why is Mrs. Mallard told the news carefully?

   A. She is deaf

   B. She has heart trouble

   C. She is very young

   D. She is pregnant

   Key: B (She has heart trouble)

8. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What do the doctors say killed her?

   A. Poison

   B. A fall

   C. Heart disease, the joy that kills

   D. Grief

   Key: C (Heart disease, the joy that kills)

9. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “She was young, with a fair, calm face, whose lines bespoke _____ and even a certain strength.” Word bank: composedly, coursing, repression, elusive

   Key: repression

10. [mc · inference · DOK 2] Which choice best states a central concern of “The Story of an Hour”?

    A. A girl choosing nature over a stranger's approval

    B. Brotherhood against an indifferent sea

    C. A woman's brief taste of freedom

    D. A choice the reader must make

    Key: C (A woman's brief taste of freedom)

11. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? “afflicted with a heart trouble” (The Story of an Hour, paragraph 1) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: Literal and symbolic.

12. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? “Free! Body and soul free” (The Story of an Hour, paragraph 12) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: Realization.

13. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “The Story of an Hour”? The doctors misread her death.

    A. Simile

    B. Hyperbole

    C. Tone / mood

    D. Irony

    Key: D (Irony)

14. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Claim: Chopin uses irony to show that Louise's death comes from lost freedom, not joy. Explain how this evidence supports the claim: “of the joy that kills” (The Story of an Hour, paragraph 19).

    Sample answer: She whispers "Free! Body and soul free!", and when her husband returns the doctors say she died "of the joy that kills," a diagnosis the reader knows is wrong.

15. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “The Story of an Hour”? Spring this device outside her window signals new life.

    A. Imagery
    B. Characterization
    C. Tone / mood
    D. Structure

    Key: A (Imagery)

16. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “afflicted with a heart trouble” (The Story of an Hour, paragraph 1) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

    Sample answer: Literal and symbolic.

17. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Analyze the word choice in “of the joy that kills” (The Story of an Hour, paragraph 19). Pick two words and explain what they suggest.

    Sample answer: The ironic end.

18. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Evaluate this claim about the story: “Chopin uses irony to show that Louise's death comes from lost freedom, not joy.” Is it fully persuasive? Argue with evidence, including a passage that complicates it.

    Sample answer: She whispers "Free! Body and soul free!", and when her husband returns the doctors say she died "of the joy that kills," a diagnosis the reader knows is wrong.

19. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Synthesis: trace how freedom and marriage develops from an earlier story to “The Story of an Hour”. Use one quotation from each.

    Sample answer: she does not hate her husband but loves her freedom.

20. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “Free! Body and soul free” (The Story of an Hour, paragraph 12) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

    Sample answer: Realization.

21. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “It was not a glance of reflection, but rather indicated a suspension of intelligent thought.”, what does “intelligent” most nearly mean?

    A. in a self-collected or self-possessed manner
    B. flowing quickly
    C. hard to grasp, catch or put into words
    D. having the capacity for thought and reason especially to a high degree

    Key: D (having the capacity for thought and reason especially to a high degree)

22. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “Her pulses beat fast, and the coursing blood warmed and relaxed every inch of her body.”, what does “coursing” most nearly mean?

    A. flowing quickly
    B. hard to grasp, catch or put into words
    C. in a self-collected or self-possessed manner

D. having the capacity for thought and reason especially to a high degree

Key: A (flowing quickly)

23. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line "It was Brently Mallard who entered, a little travel-stained, composedly carrying his grip-sack and umbrella.", what does "composedly" most nearly mean?

A. in a self-collected or self-possessed manner

B. flowing quickly

C. hard to grasp, catch or put into words

D. having the capacity for thought and reason especially to a high degree

Key: A (in a self-collected or self-possessed manner)

24. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line "She did not know; it was too subtle and elusive to name.", what does "elusive" most nearly mean?

A. hard to grasp, catch or put into words

B. in a self-collected or self-possessed manner

C. having the capacity for thought and reason especially to a high degree

D. flowing quickly

Key: A (hard to grasp, catch or put into words)

Rigor version	Items (in order)	Mix
Scaffolded support	1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15, 16	recall 9, inference 3, analysis 3, synthesis 1
HS Freshman	4, 9, 1, 2, 6, 3, 5, 7, 8, 10, 11, 12, 14, 17, 13, 18	recall 9, inference 3, analysis 3, synthesis 1
HS Sophomore	8, 5, 3, 6, 7, 2, 9, 4, 11, 12, 10, 13, 17, 14, 19, 20	recall 8, inference 3, analysis 3, synthesis 2
HS Junior	6, 5, 2, 3, 4, 1, 8, 11, 10, 12, 17, 13, 15, 14, 19, 18	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 2
HS Senior	4, 2, 5, 7, 9, 3, 11, 12, 10, 17, 14, 13, 15, 18, 16, 19	recall 6, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 3
AP	9, 7, 4, 21, 22, 10, 11, 12, 14, 17, 13, 15, 20, 18, 19, 16	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Freshman	23, 5, 4, 24, 9, 10, 11, 12, 17, 14, 13, 15, 20, 19, 18, 16	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Sophomore	9, 1, 24, 22, 5, 10, 12, 11, 13, 14, 15, 17, 20, 19, 18, 16	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Junior	2, 23, 3, 5, 4, 12, 11, 10, 17, 15, 14, 13, 18, 20, 19, 16	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Senior	3, 5, 22, 2, 21, 10, 12, 11, 17, 15, 14, 13, 19, 20, 18, 16	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
Graduate / PhD	4, 9, 24, 1, 2, 12, 11, 10, 13, 17, 15, 14, 18, 19, 16, 20	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Scaffolded support (250 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.1, W.9-10.1): Supported track (work from the passage your teacher selects). In "The Story of an Hour," how does Chopin show a woman's brief taste of freedom? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the irony you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.1, W.9-10.1): In The Story of an Hour, how does Chopin develop the idea of a woman's brief taste of freedom? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the irony in the story helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.1, W.9-10.1): Analyze how The Story of an Hour develops the idea of a woman's brief taste of freedom. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of irony and imagery shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.9): Analyze how the structure of The Story of an Hour (where it begins, turns and ends) and its irony shape the reader's understanding of a woman's brief taste of freedom. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning. Distinguish what is directly stated from what is really meant.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.6, W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.9): Two readers disagree about what The Story of an Hour suggests about a woman's brief taste of freedom. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the story's irony and imagery), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay. Distinguish what is directly stated from what is really meant.

AP (650 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.6, W.11-12.1): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how Kate Chopin uses irony in The Story of an Hour to complicate the reader's understanding of a woman's brief taste of freedom. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Situate The Story of an Hour within its historical and literary context and argue how the story's treatment of a woman's brief taste of freedom responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Read The Story of an Hour alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the story's handling of a woman's brief taste of freedom follows or bends those conventions, using the irony as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to The Story of an Hour and its treatment of a woman's brief taste of freedom. State your method, show what it reveals in the story's irony and imagery, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Develop a research argument that reads The Story of an Hour as evidence for a larger claim about a woman's brief taste of freedom in The Story of an Hour. Connect close reading of the story to the whole story, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Develop an original argument that reads The Story of an Hour as a hinge in the story's larger treatment of a woman's brief taste of freedom. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on The Story of an Hour.

SAT-style questions

1. *It was Brently Mallard who entered, a little travel-stained, composedly carrying his grip-sack and umbrella.*

   As used in the text, what does the word “composedly” most nearly mean?

   A. without knowing or intending

   B. sudden understanding; a flash of insight

   C. continuing firmly in spite of difficulty

   D. in a self-collected or self-possessed manner

2. *She was young, with a fair, calm face, whose lines bespoke repression and even a certain strength. But now there was a dull stare in her eyes, whose gaze was fixed away off yonder on one of those patches of blue sky. It was not a glance of reflection, but rather indicated a suspension of intelligent thought.*

   Which choice best states a central concern of “The Story of an Hour”?

   A. A woman's brief taste of freedom

   B. A family and a house collapsing together

   C. Endurance turning to justice

   D. Love and rivalry destroyed by racial violence

SAT key: 1. D (in a self-collected or self-possessed manner); 2. A (A woman's brief taste of freedom)

Unit test

The Story of an Hour: end test · 90 minutes · 18 questions per rigor version (multiple choice, fill in the blank, short answer). The class rigor level picks the version; student auto-adjust applies.

Short-answer scoring guides

Scaffolded support and HS Freshman (2 points): correct answer in a complete sentence with a detail from the text. HS Sophomore to HS Senior (3 points): claim, one accurate quotation, one sentence of explanation. AP to College Sophomore (4 points): precise claim, two embedded quotations, commentary on word choice or structure, link to theme. College Junior to Graduate (5 points): nuanced thesis, close reading of two passages, synthesis across sections, a competing reading answered. Each item lists a sample answer; partial credit is described in the app.

Unit test: item bank (all eleven rigor versions)

1. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “There would be no powerful will bending hers in that blind _____ with which men and women believe they have a right to impose a private will upon a fellow-creature.” Word bank: elusive, coursing, persistence, composedly

   Key: persistence
2. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “She was young, with a fair, calm face, whose lines bespoke _____ and even a certain strength.” Word bank: composedly, coursing, repression, elusive

   Key: repression
3. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What word does she whisper?

   A. Gone

   B. Lost

   C. Alone

   D. Free

   Key: D (Free)
4. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Why is Mrs. Mallard told the news carefully?

   A. She is deaf

   B. She has heart trouble

   C. She is very young

   D. She is pregnant

   Key: B (She has heart trouble)
5. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “It was not a glance of reflection, but rather indicated a _____ of intelligent thought.” Word bank: suspension, composedly, elusive, coursing

   Key: suspension
6. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “Now her bosom rose and fell _____.”

   Word bank: elusive, coursing, composedly, tumultuously

   Key: tumultuously

7. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Who first brings the news?

   A. Brently himself

   B. The doctor

   C. A telegram boy

   D. Her sister Josephine and Richards

   Key: D (Her sister Josephine and Richards)

8. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What does she see from her window?

   A. A train

   B. A funeral

   C. Signs of spring and new life

   D. Rain and fog

   Key: C (Signs of spring and new life)

9. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What do the doctors say killed her?

   A. Poison

   B. A fall

   C. Heart disease, the joy that kills

   D. Grief

   Key: C (Heart disease, the joy that kills)

10. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? “Free! Body and soul free” (The Story of an Hour, paragraph 12) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: Realization.

11. [mc · inference · DOK 2] Which choice best states a central concern of “The Story of an Hour”?

    A. A girl choosing nature over a stranger's approval

    B. Brotherhood against an indifferent sea

    C. A woman's brief taste of freedom

    D. A choice the reader must make

    Key: C (A woman's brief taste of freedom)

12. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? “afflicted with a heart trouble” (The Story of an Hour, paragraph 1) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: Literal and symbolic.

13. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “The Story of an Hour”? The doctors misread her death.

    A. Simile

    B. Hyperbole

    C. Tone / mood

    D. Irony

    Key: D (Irony)

14. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Claim: Chopin uses irony to show that Louise's death comes from lost freedom, not joy. Explain how this evidence supports the claim: “of the joy that kills” (The Story of an Hour, paragraph 19).

Sample answer: She whispers "Free! Body and soul free!", and when her husband returns the doctors say she died "of the joy that kills," a diagnosis the reader knows is wrong.

15. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Analyze the word choice in “of the joy that kills” (The Story of an Hour, paragraph 19). Pick two words and explain what they suggest.
    Sample answer: The ironic end.
16. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “The Story of an Hour”? Spring this device outside her window signals new life.
    A. Imagery
    B. Characterization
    C. Tone / mood
    D. Structure

    Key: A (Imagery)
17. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “Free! Body and soul free” (The Story of an Hour, paragraph 12) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.
    Sample answer: Realization.
18. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Evaluate this claim about the story: “Chopin uses irony to show that Louise's death comes from lost freedom, not joy.” Is it fully persuasive? Argue with evidence, including a passage that complicates it.
    Sample answer: She whispers "Free! Body and soul free!", and when her husband returns the doctors say she died "of the joy that kills," a diagnosis the reader knows is wrong.
19. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Synthesis: trace how freedom and marriage develops from an earlier story to “The Story of an Hour”. Use one quotation from each.
    Sample answer: she does not hate her husband but loves her freedom.
20. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “afflicted with a heart trouble” (The Story of an Hour, paragraph 1) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.
    Sample answer: Literal and symbolic.
21. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “It was not a glance of reflection, but rather indicated a suspension of intelligent thought.”, what does “intelligent” most nearly mean?
    A. in a self-collected or self-possessed manner
    B. flowing quickly
    C. hard to grasp, catch or put into words
    D. having the capacity for thought and reason especially to a high degree

    Key: D (having the capacity for thought and reason especially to a high degree)
22. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “She did not know; it was too subtle and elusive to name.”, what does “elusive” most nearly mean?
    A. hard to grasp, catch or put into words
    B. in a self-collected or self-possessed manner
    C. having the capacity for thought and reason especially to a high degree
    D. flowing quickly

    Key: A (hard to grasp, catch or put into words)

23. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line "It was Brently Mallard who entered, a little travel-stained, composedly carrying his grip-sack and umbrella.", what does "composedly" most nearly mean?

    A. in a self-collected or self-possessed manner

    B. flowing quickly

    C. hard to grasp, catch or put into words

    D. having the capacity for thought and reason especially to a high degree

    Key: A (in a self-collected or self-possessed manner)

24. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line "Her pulses beat fast, and the coursing blood warmed and relaxed every inch of her body.", what does "coursing" most nearly mean?

    A. flowing quickly

    B. hard to grasp, catch or put into words

    C. in a self-collected or self-possessed manner

    D. having the capacity for thought and reason especially to a high degree

    Key: A (flowing quickly)

Rigor version	Items (in order)	Mix
Scaffolded support	1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18	recall 9, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 2
HS Freshman	9, 6, 1, 7, 8, 5, 2, 3, 4, 11, 12, 10, 13, 14, 15, 16, 19, 18	recall 9, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 2
HS Sophomore	7, 3, 9, 5, 8, 6, 2, 1, 4, 11, 12, 10, 15, 14, 16, 13, 20, 19	recall 9, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 2
HS Junior	8, 7, 2, 6, 3, 1, 4, 9, 5, 12, 11, 10, 15, 16, 13, 14, 17, 18	recall 9, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 2
HS Senior	7, 6, 5, 8, 9, 2, 3, 1, 11, 12, 10, 13, 16, 15, 14, 18, 17, 20	recall 8, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 3
AP	2, 21, 8, 22, 5, 4, 9, 11, 10, 12, 14, 16, 13, 15, 19, 20, 17, 18	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Freshman	2, 6, 8, 3, 7, 9, 23, 11, 12, 10, 15, 13, 16, 14, 19, 20, 18, 17	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Sophomore	8, 23, 21, 3, 1, 7, 6, 12, 11, 10, 14, 13, 16, 15, 19, 20, 17, 18	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Junior	21, 1, 9, 22, 3, 8, 5, 10, 11, 12, 14, 15, 16, 13, 18, 20, 19, 17	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Senior	23, 22, 9, 21, 1, 6, 5, 10, 11, 12, 14, 13, 16, 15, 17, 18, 20, 19	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
Graduate / PhD	2, 24, 22, 21, 3, 9, 6, 10, 11, 12, 13, 16, 15, 14, 18, 20, 17, 19	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4

Final paper

The Story of an Hour: final paper (formal literary analysis). Choose one prompt.

1. Analyze how Kate Chopin develops freedom and marriage across The Story of an Hour. Trace the idea through at least three moments (beginning, middle and end) and argue what the ending finally suggests.
2. Choose one recurring symbol, image or motif in The Story of an Hour and argue how its meaning changes over the story and why that change matters to identity.
3. Analyze a central character's choices in The Story of an Hour. Argue whether the story judges that character, and how its structure or point of view shapes your answer.
4. Two readers disagree about whether The Story of an Hour finally endorses or criticizes its society's view of irony of joy. Weigh both readings and argue for one, answering the strongest objection.

Length: Scaffolded support 500-700 words; HS Freshman 700-900 words; HS Sophomore 900-1,100 words; HS Junior 1,000-1,300 words; HS Senior 1,200-1,500 words; AP 1,300-1,600 words; College Freshman 1,500-2,000 words; College Sophomore 2,000-2,500 words; College Junior 2,500-3,000 words; College Senior 3,000-4,000 words; Graduate / PhD 4,000-6,000 words

Evidence requirement: at least 4 quotations from at least two parts of the story. Quote the reading text exactly and cite the paragraph (MLA style). HS Senior and above: one scholarly or historical source; College Sophomore and above: two, cited in MLA.

Criterion	Points	Descriptor
Thesis	20	A specific, arguable claim that answers the prompt and organizes the paper.
Evidence	25	Well-chosen, accurately quoted and cited passages from across the work, meeting the evidence requirement.
Analysis	30	Explains how language, structure and literary elements create meaning; goes beyond summary.
Organization	15	Logical progression, clear topic sentences and transitions; introduction and conclusion frame the argument.
Style and conventions	10	Formal academic voice, present tense for literature, correct grammar and MLA format.

Essay assignments

Essay: Freedom and marriage

Scaffolded support (600 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Supported track: write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Story of an Hour teaches about freedom and marriage. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Kate Chopin develops freedom and marriage in The Story of an Hour. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Kate Chopin develops freedom and marriage across The Story of an Hour. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Story of an Hour (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of freedom and marriage. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of freedom and marriage in The Story of an Hour. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Kate Chopin's choices in The Story of an Hour (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of freedom and marriage, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Story of an Hour's treatment of freedom and marriage in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on freedom and marriage in The Story of an Hour that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on freedom and marriage in The Story of an Hour. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about freedom and marriage in The Story of an Hour, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on freedom and marriage in The Story of an Hour, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Identity

Scaffolded support (600 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Supported track: write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Story of an Hour teaches about identity. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Kate Chopin develops identity in The Story of an Hour. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Kate Chopin develops identity across The Story of an Hour. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Story of an Hour (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of identity. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of identity in The Story of an Hour. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Kate Chopin's choices in The Story of an Hour (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of identity, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Story of an Hour's treatment of identity in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on identity in The Story of an Hour that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

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Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on identity in The Story of an Hour, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Irony of joy

Scaffolded support (600 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Supported track: write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Story of an Hour teaches about irony of joy. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Kate Chopin develops irony of joy in The Story of an Hour. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Kate Chopin develops irony of joy across The Story of an Hour. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Story of an Hour (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of irony of joy. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of irony of joy in The Story of an Hour. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Kate Chopin's choices in The Story of an Hour (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of irony of joy, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Story of an Hour's treatment of irony of joy in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on irony of joy in The Story of an Hour that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

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Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

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